

December 9, 1943

MEMORANDUM FOR THE FILES

I had luncheon today with Bernard Meltzer, now an Ensign in the Navy, and formerly Acting Chief of the Foreign Funds Control Division of the State Department. I arranged this luncheon specifically with Meltzer with the end in mind that I might obtain from him such information as he had relating to the financial program for the evacuation of Jews from France and Rumania. At the time that the cable of August 6 (stating that the Treasury was prepared to issue license in this matter) was sent out, Meltzer had called me and told me that he had been instructed by the State Department to say that State had no comments to make on the proposal, but that State would raise no objections to the Treasury issuing a license with respect to the transaction. Meltzer made it clear at that time that he thought State Department's method of handling the matter made no sense and further indicated his bitter resentment of the way the matter was being handled. He told me at that time that he would like to discuss the matter in more detail with me "after he was in the Army".

I told Meltzer of the delays which had occurred in connection with this matter and he immediately volunteered to furnish me with such information as he had on the subject. He thereupon proceeded to relate the following story:

(1) At the time this matter originally arose in the Department, in April of this year, the cables from Berne transmitting messages from Riegner were referred to Dr. Herbert Feis by Sumner Welles. Normally this type of communication would probably have been referred to the Special Division under Breckinridge Long. Whether Welles referred this to Feis because of the economic aspects of the problem or because he felt that Feis would be most apt to react favorably, Meltzer said he did not know. Feis called Meltzer in on the problem. They put their heads together and, having decided that this would be a matter which would probably be opposed by Long and his crowd, they mapped their plans accordingly.